

Monsoon Letters

When the first monsoon rain reached the town, the post office roof turned into a drum. Saraswati, the clerk with the careful handwriting, slid bags of letters away from the leaks and brewed ginger tea on a blue flame. Outside, the lane became a silver thread; inside, the room smelled like paper, cloves, and damp earth. She liked to think the rain read every stamp, tasting each corner of the world before letting the ink dry again.

Near closing time a soaked man arrived with a parcel wrapped in old newspaper. He ordered milk tea, then admitted he was afraid his work would never be good enough too many ideas, he said, and none of them finished. Binu nodded, as if she had been waiting all week for that exact confession. Saraswati weighed the box and asked for a return address. The man shook his head. Send it anywhere, he said, wherever someone needs to hear a voice they haven't heard in years. Saraswati paused with her pen hovering, then wrote a name from a file that had sat unclaimed for months.

After he left, the lights flickered and went out. In the dark, the rain kept drumming and the radio inside the parcel began to whisper—soft, like someone practicing a song in another room. Saraswati listened, imagining it traveling north on a mail truck, then higher still on a mule path, until it reached a kitchen where a window looked over terraces washed clean. A woman there would set down her bowl, turn, and say, Is that you? The radio would not answer, but the room would feel less empty. Saraswati sealed the parcel and smiled. Some letters did not need words.